

5

P2P~Peering into the future

Napster has gone down as one of the most popular music sharing hubs in recent history. What made P2P so popular was not the notion of getting music for nothing, but P2P's ability to let the masses share and communicate without a central authority to intervene. While the RIAA viewed it as a music piracy racket, businesses see P2P as collaborative growth. P2P essentially allows bypassing large networks or centralised servers and connecting directly with other computers. This concept is not new, and more people are now discovering the potential of this technology.

While movies and music seem the logical use for P2P, the scope in the office space is also quite vast. P2P can help in collaboration tools that include e-mail, whiteboards, calendar, and so on.

Some of this is already evident in Groove, a software that's still in the beta stage. Project JXTA of Sun Microsystems is a collection of low-level protocols for building peer-to-peer applications. The emphasis is on grouping nodes together so that people can talk in small groups; piping, so the output of one service or node can reach another service; and metering and monitoring.

6

Biometrics~All in the genes

The study of discernible biological characteristics is at the heart of Biometric research. From retinal scans to fingerprint verification, Biometrics is difficult to fool as it scrutinises aspects that are unique to each of us. With Biometric technology, you are your own password. Companies are turning to Biometrics to enhance their user verification systems and maintain a high level of customer service. E-commerce is another area that will benefit hugely from this form of identification. Biometrics could symbolise a whole new way of conducting payment transfers and at the same time save on the cost involved in servicing fraudulent orders. By 2003, the global pool of Biometric systems will encompass a good number of wealthy and medium sized enterprises. By 2005, consumers will begin to experience Biometrics on a much wider scale.

7

XML~Exchange of data

XML (eXtensible Markup Language) is slowly becoming the language standard on the Web. XML is not only platform independent, but it can also consist of various logical templates describing how to send and characterise the data. XML can be seen as a major tool for the domain of knowledge management or document management systems, especially in coding and passing content from various

sources or file formats into one entity.

Since XML also stores raw data in addition to defining it, it currently has the potential to replace databases, in some instances, while retaining the ability to create dynamic Web sites. High-end tools are not yet available for XML data management and manipulation; that job is currently reserved for high-powered databases.

Based on Unicode, XML provides global language support, which could literally turn itself into a tool to enable cross-country commerce. One of the biggest complaints emerging from e-commerce is the inconsistency of language platforms and the inability to send and receive compatible data across servers. XML overcomes this by forcing together a set of standards and ensuring transparency.